Fading Lines

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61495636.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta (She-Ra), Catra & Lonnie (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Lonnie & Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - College/University, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, It Gets Worse Before It Gets Better, It Gets Worse, Slow Burn, Flashbacks, Second Chances, toxic but a good toxic, catradora

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by feralcocomellon

Summary

IN PROGRESS
Adora and Catra are both dealing with deep emotional baggage, and their rivalry has turned into a mix of tension and unspoken feelings. Adora is struggling with guilt, loneliness, and the pressure of her parents' expectations after leaving her old life behind. Catra, determined to prove herself, keeps her walls high and her emotions guarded.

Despite their constant bickering, a simmering attraction between them can’t be ignored. As they navigate grad school, personal insecurities, and the weight of their shared past, they’re forced to confront painful memories and feelings that still connect them. The story follows their journey of healing, forgiveness, and the slow burn of enemies to lovers, filled with emotional tension and awkward moments.

Notes

Howdy! ;) Thanks for reading! <3

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Chapter 1 Adora

The first key did not work, nor did the second or the third. Adora huffed as she attempted to balance her water bottle, backpack, tote, and the bag of groceries she had picked up on her way home in one hand while fumbling with the keys, trying to finally pick the right one. After two more attempts, the lock finally clicked. The blonde released a breath of relief as she practically scrambled into the apartment, setting the groceries and bottle on the kitchen island and practically launching her bags onto the couch. She let her shoulders relax, and, for the first time in a week, finally took an actual break.

Adora’s parents had made a surprise trip to Cambridge, Massachusetts, to visit their daughter—a sweet gesture, of course, but the trip had not been planned. The moment her parents walked in the door, Adora had begun to scramble. She was grateful they had made the trip from California, but with grad school starting the next week, Adora couldn't help cursing under her breath as she gave up her room and was forced to sleep on the rock-hard couch.

The past week had sent a tornado of feelings reeling through her. She was tired, annoyed, sore, and stressed. Her mother had nagged her the entire week about staying on top of coursework, making sure she bought groceries, and preparing meal preps for the first week of school—not to mention the total renovation of Adora’s apartment that had taken place. A cleaning crew swept through every nook and cranny, old clothes were donated, and by the end of the week, Adora had gotten a new couch to sleep on—which somehow managed to be harder than the first.

Adora’s father, on the other hand, had attended every game Adora had coached. He had managed to dispense all the knowledge a man could possibly have about women’s sports. She smiled politely the entire time and promised him she would tell her girls

his advice. Having graduated from Harvard and played basketball there, the university was bound and determined to have her on the coaching staff as soon as possible—once she was "comfortable." *Comfortable* was the word the institution chose to use when they offered her the position, expecting anyone who had just double-majored in Kinesiology and Legal History to want at least a couple of months off before stepping back onto campus, especially someone who had applied to their graduate school for the next fall. But Adora practically jumped at the opportunity to have something to do after her last three years of pure hell.

It wasn't easy—no, it was nearly impossible—for Adora during college. Her life had been twisted, shaped, and molded for her more times than she could count. She hadn't gotten into Harvard after high school. It had been her dream—well, her parents' dream. They wanted her to continue the family legacy at the school.

The blonde rubbed her fingers on her temple as the memories came flashing back.

She had just gotten home from practice. The blonde, seventeen at the time, was happy, her workload next to nothing. She remembered walking into the kitchen to find her mother sitting at the counter with her laptop open in front of her, a look of total disbelief on her face.

She had been waitlisted.

After three months had passed, Adora walked across the stage of her high school as their Valedictorian. She had been accepted to the University of California, Los Angeles, where she would major in kinesiology and play for their women's basketball team. She had never been happier.

Her parents smiled politely, but the disappointment was palpable in every glance. She had fought that look her entire life, and the feeling of failure tore through her abdomen like a knife. It never

got easier, nor did it become less painful. This was a never-ending battle for the adoptive daughter of the Grays.

Adora was practically slapped out of her thoughts when her phone began to ring. She glanced down at the screen, expecting to see her mother calling, but to her surprise, it was Glimmer. She grabbed the phone and answered, setting it on speaker as she began sorting through her groceries.

"Hey," Adora's voice was hoarse from the scrimmage, as usual. Calling out plays over the crowd, yelling at the refs, and trying to get through to her teammates had permanently left a rasp in her voice.

"Dor, what are you wearing tomorrow?" Glimmer's high-pitched voice filled the empty apartment like a blanket. She sounded distant, as though she was currently scouring her closet for the "perfect" outfit.

"Uh... Clothes?" Adora responded, opening the fridge.

Glimmer had been the first person Adora met after transferring to Harvard. She was the first friendly face after everything, and Adora had latched onto her. Not long after, Adora met Glimmer's childhood best friend, Bow. The three became inseparable for the next three years. Glimmer and Bow were both considered legacies, just like Adora. Glimmer, like her mother, majored in political science, while Bow majored in education. The three would all be attending Harvard for another one to seven years, depending on how long they wanted to stay.

"Ha. Ha. Now seriously, I know your mother picked you out an outfit. Just tell me— is it nice?"

Glimmer's tone tried to sound sarcastic but came out more stressed. She was right—Adora's mother had indeed picked out an outfit. A heather gray sweater, a white dress shirt, and black dress pants had been hung on the tall windowsill in the apartment last night. Her mother practically packed Adora's backpack for her.

Adora placed the last bits of groceries into the fridge, grabbing a bottle of water and a protein bar before making her way over to the couch.

“A gray sweater, black pants, and a white dress shirt,” Adora replied, taking a drink of her water.

“What shoes?”

Glimmer’s voice sounded closer now. Adora chuckled and slipped her tennis shoes off, tossing them on the floor at the bottom of the couch.

“Crocs, Glimmer. I’m going to wear Crocs.”

The blonde's voice oozed with irony. Glimmer let out a loud, dramatic sigh, and muffled sounds filled Adora’s ears. The phone call screen disappeared as a FaceTime call replaced it. The blonde huffed as she swiped to answer.

“Well, hello there."

Adora chuckled at the sight of Glimmer and Bow's apartment.

“Adora! Seriously, can you help me?”

A head of purple hair blocked the camera as the female reached into her closet. True to form, Glimmer decided to go against the "status quo." The act of deviance had started during their junior year of college and seemed to remain strong through grad school.

Adora loved Glimmer and Bow. The two of them had taken a heartbroken girl and done their best to piece her heart back together. After moving across the country and leaving everything and everyone behind, Adora had been at her lowest. She was tired all the time, and lost motivation for school, sports, and life altogether. That was until these two bubbles of joy stepped into her life and gave her a flashlight, allowing her to see past the darker parts.

Leaving UCLA had been one of the darkest moments of her life. Her parents hadn't given her a choice—well, not a real one. The moment Adora had received an email from Harvard saying she had been accepted and taken off the waitlist, her parents immediately began enrolling her, finding her an apartment, and buying furniture.

Adora wasn't even sure how her parents had found out she'd been accepted, but somehow, they did. She remembered the night they asked her to go to dinner. She knew something was off, but chose to stay silent. The second she arrived, it was practically a giant party. All her family members and her parents' friends were gathered around a table at the restaurant. Her parents got what they wanted the only way they knew how—by asking her what she wanted to do in front of everyone she would never, not once in her life, think of letting down. She said she would go, but she had hoped to at least finish her first semester at UCLA. She had hoped to play a few more months with her teammates. They had just started the actual season and had already played five games. Everything was perfect. Even her roommate.

Adora flinched at the memory. She had spent the past four years trying to forget about her—her laugh, her smile, and their time together. Time helped, but guilt was an ugly feeling. Adora was sure her past roommate didn't think about her. She was probably living her best life. She had most likely graduated by now, hopefully still performing at restaurants and bars in her free time.

The blonde forced herself out of her thoughts, attempting to blink away the past.

"Honestly, Glimmer, I'm most likely going to wear my nicer tennis shoes," Adora said, her voice distant.

After four outfit changes, three hairdos, and more shoes than Adora could count, Glimmer finally decided on an outfit. Adora practically fell back onto the couch once the purple-haired girl had made up her mind. All the blonde wanted to do was sleep—

granted, it was only seven at night, but after her week, she needed all the rest she could get.

Just as she was about to announce that she was going to head off the call, Glimmer spoke.

“Hey, me and Bow are going to grab dinner and drinks at The Grill. Wanna come?”

Adora’s face dropped at the offer.

“Probably not, Glim. I’m exhausted.”

It was true—Adora was more tired than usual. She had already changed into sweats and even managed to find a show to watch.

“Come on, Adora, you can’t possibly not need an alcoholic beverage after a week with your parents.”

Bow's face now completely filled her phone screen as he spoke. She laughed at his choice of wording.

“I really don’t want to.”

The blonde whined as she sank back into the couch.

“Too bad. We’ll be there in thirty minutes. Get dressed, I’m not letting you become a crazy cat lady at the ripe age of twenty-two.”

Adora huffed as the phone call ended.

What the actual hell, she thought to herself. But she pulled herself off the couch and made her way to her room and closet.

She managed to find some green pants and a black shirt to throw on. Her head had been throbbing, so instead of her usual ponytail, she left her hair down. She slipped on her tennis shoes and grabbed a black jacket from the coat closet in the entryway before making her way back to the couch.

The Grill was a restaurant and bar they had found in their junior year. They loved the atmosphere of the place. Most college students went downtown for the bars, so not many...

They went to The Grill, a restaurant that always had live performers or karaoke going on, and the owners were pretty sweet overall.

After ten minutes, someone began pounding on the door. Adora, with the biggest look of confusion, rushed to the door, thinking something had happened.

“Hello?” she asked, only to be met with purple hair.

“Come on! Let's go!” Glimmer exclaimed.

Adora barely had time to grab her wallet and keys before she was yanked out of her apartment. Once the two were in the elevator, the blonde finally spoke.

“The hell, Glimmer?”

An annoyed sigh followed her sentence. She ran her fingers through her blonde hair as she double-checked that she had everything.

“Relax. The Uber driver is a total tool and wasn’t happy about making the stop. I didn’t want you to get distracted,” Glimmer replied, scrolling through her phone.

Adora watched her for a second, then reached into her back pocket for her phone—only to realize, in her rush, she had forgotten it.

“Glimmer, you made me leave my phone. I’ve gotta go get it.”

Adora’s voice was tired with annoyance as she rubbed her temples.

Glimmer just smiled as she grabbed Adora's hand and yanked her out of the elevator.

"You act like you have any other friends. Your parents just left, they won't be texting you, and you'll have me and Bow's phones in case of an emergency. You have your money and your keys. You. Are. Fine." She took a break between each word as she emphasized, "You are fine."

Adora just mumbled under her breath as she followed Glimmer to the black car sitting outside the apartment lobby.

The air was crisp now that it had turned dark. Adora loved the fall here. The leaves were dying, but somehow, they looked even more beautiful than when they were alive. The colder weather was something she cherished, especially after living in California her whole life.

Glimmer climbed in first, sitting behind the driver, while Adora sat in the seat behind Bow.

"Long time no see, Adora. I was wondering when they were going to let you free," Bow said, smiling as he turned in his seat to face the blonde.

"No kidding," Adora replied, fastening her seatbelt.

The drive was short—no more than a fifteen-minute trip from her apartment to the side of Cambridge that had some restaurants, shops, and bars. The car slowed to a stop right outside the building. A small sign illuminated the entrance with blue and red letters spelling out "The Grill."

The group thanked the driver as they crawled out, all pitching in to leave a decent tip. Adora looked across the street to the parking lot and noticed more cars than usual. The sound of music and talking filled her ears as Bow opened the door to the bar.

"I know, I know. I'm such a gentleman," he laughed, joking as the two girls walked in.

The three smiled at a couple of waitresses and the bartender as they made their way to a table near the stage. Adora awkwardly waved at some people who sent her smiles as she passed by.

“You know, you really haven’t gotten any less socially awkward, even after knowing us for almost four years. I’m kind of offended,” Glimmer said, raising her voice over the music.

Adora glared at her, and Bow laughed at the pair as they bickered.

“How is that,” Adora motioned to the restaurant behind her, “socially awkward? I don’t even know any of these people, and they’re all smiling at me like I’m at a family reunion.”

The music was louder than usual, and the crowd, which had mostly been older folks, was now slowly being overtaken by people their age. The bar, which usually had one bartender, now had two running around frantically. Even their waitress, who eventually made her way to the trio's table, seemed a bit overwhelmed by the usual amount of customers.

After ordering drinks and some food, Bow gave Adora a look.

“Don’t act like you’d be any less awkward at a family reunion.”

Adora, knowing it was the truth, stayed silent, trying her best not to smile while looking away.

The night seemed to get busier—whenever one group left, it felt like two more arrived. About thirty minutes after their food had been brought out, a second round of drinks arrived.

The once unpopulated area of the restaurant was now filled.

“Is someone performing?” Glimmer asked the two.

Adora noted that questions like this were rare—usually, no one sat in this area on a Sunday night because there were no performances scheduled.

“It didn’t say anything on the website, did it?” Bow looked at Adora.

“Why would I know? One of you forced me to come. Also, Glimmer wouldn’t let me go back to grab my phone after practically kidnapping me out of my apartment,” Adora said, sending another glare toward the other female.

Glimmer just smiled sarcastically as she pulled out her phone to look up the website. While Glimmer looked, Adora turned her attention to Bow.

“Are you excited? For tomorrow?” Adora asked. Like her, Bow had initially wanted to do something completely different than what they were doing now. If you were to ask younger Adora and Bow:

“Hey, what would you want to be when you grow up?”

Neither of them would have said, *I want to be a professor and teach for the rest of my life,* or *Yes, I want to be a legal historian,* but yet here they were—fulfilling the dreams of their parents. Unable to say anything other than yes, and *Is there anything else I can do?*

“Sure, gotta get my master's, then my PhD, then I’m all set to live the dream,” Bow shot her with two finger guns, causing the blonde to laugh. She understood. Five to seven years of studying anything about the law and its history? Fun stuff.

“I found it!” Glimmer’s scream shocked both Adora and Bow, pulling them out of their thoughts. The female flipped her phone around to show them.

“Fading Lines are playing tonight,” Glimmer announced. She flipped her phone back around to read the band’s biography. “The lead singer is originally from California, she moved here to attend Harvard graduate school—twins!” She flashed the two a smile. “The guitarist, drummer, and bassist are from Cambridge. Twins times two!” She kept reading. “They have some pretty good

reviews so far. Oh, they've been performing for… only five months? Dang, I guess they are pretty good."

Adora shot a look at Bow, only to find him already looking at her. That sent them both into a laughing fit. Glimmer looked up from her phone.

"You guys literally asked me to find this stuff out."

The pair continued laughing, trying to hold in their drinks.

"Oh my god, y'all are so drunk."

This sent Adora over the edge. She spit her drink onto the floor. Trying to catch her breath, she reached for a napkin. A waitress rushed over to help.

"No, please, I did it. Let me clean it up," Adora said, laughing as she wiped the spill with napkins.

Glimmer just smiled as she took a drink from her cup. Bow was still giggling beside her while Adora cleaned up her mess.

After attempting to clean up most of the spill, Adora began to stand up but heard someone clear their throat. She shot up too quickly, hitting her head and shoulder on the table before managing to get herself off the floor.

"Sorry, that's my bad. I was cleaning up the mess. Let me just grab the towel off the floor," Adora explained, kneeling down again to grab the towel.

"I mean, I'm flattered, but don't you think it's a bit early?" a stranger's voice said.

Adora mentally noted the sass in her tone. She was about to ask what the stranger meant—or if they thought she was someone else—until she realized the position she was in. Here she was, on a knee in front of a woman at a bar, like a proposal.

Adora shot up faster than she could think, hitting her shoulder on the table again. After setting the towel on the table and running her fingers through her hair, she finally got a good look at the stranger. Messy curly brown hair, two completely different colored eyes, and tan skin. This sassy stranger was beautiful. The kind of beauty that didn't need makeup or a fancy outfit. The stranger had neither—just a white tank top and baggy jeans.

Adora wasn't sure what came over her, but her usual social awkwardness seemed to disappear.

"Trust me, if I was going to propose, it wouldn't be in a backstreet bar."

She smirked at the stranger.

The brunette raised an eyebrow, looking her up and down before speaking.

"I'll have to remember that."

Adora smirked before moving to allow the brunette to pass. The stranger looked her over one more time, furrowing her brows before walking past their table toward the stage area.

"Hello!" Bow practically screamed once the strangely hot female was out of earshot.

"What. The. Hell. Was that?" Glimmer whispered-yelled at Adora.

"Trust me, if I was going to propose, it wouldn't be in a backstreet bar. Okay, Dor, I see you!" Bow repeated the line Adora had used.

Adora just rolled her eyes at the pair. The two stayed on the topic for another five minutes until someone came up on stage with a microphone.

"Excuse me," the man on stage cleared his throat. "I'm sure most of you came to see the show, so I'm excited to introduce you to *Fading Lines.*"

The people in the restaurant and bar began clapping, some started to walk over and stand toward the back. One by one, the members of the band made their way to the stage. First came a female holding drumsticks, which Adora assumed was the drummer. Then two more members with guitars, and finally, the last girl walked out onto the stage.

Adora smiled. Of course, the conveniently hot stranger who had made a joke about the blonde proposing was in the band.

The man handed the microphone to her and smiled before exiting the stage.

"That's us, Fading Lines. This is Lonnie, our expert on beating things, or what some of you might call a drummer." The crowd laughed in unison as the hot, not-so-stranger pointed toward the female who looked similar to the other brunette, but different. "This is Trapta, our bassist. Her full name is Entrapata, but don't worry, she probably won't respond to either." The crowd continued giggling as she pointed toward the female on stage with long purple hair.

Adora looked over to see Glimmer pointing between the other purple-haired girl and herself.

"See, I told you it was a trend," Glimmer said.

Adora chuckled as she locked eyes with the female on stage.

"And this is my second in command, Scorpia, our other vocalist and goddess on the guitar." Adora glanced at Scorpia. The female had short platinum blonde hair and thick eyeliner. The band, Adora noted, was an attractive group overall.

"And you hopefully enjoy my voice. I'm Catra."

The brunette, Catra, looked Adora dead in the eyes.

Adora's world came to a halt.

No. No, that couldn’t be.

“Some of us up here are attending grad school here at Harvard, so every tip counts. Call us beggars, but a girl’s gotta eat.”

The crowd laughed, but Adora couldn’t bring herself to look at the stage anymore. Her roommate, her friend, her *Catra* was here. And there was nothing she could do.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Wow, well hello again! Before we dive in, let me just preface this by saying: I HAVE NEVER WRITTEN FANFICTION BEFORE —so if that wasn't already obvious, now you know! 😅 Honestly, I'm here to have fun and create a story about my favorite lesbians.
>
> I usually stick to TikTok, but I wanted to step out of my comfort zone and try writing. So far, I've been having a blast with it! I already had these first two chapters mapped out before publishing Chapter One, which is why this update is coming so quickly. That said, the next chapter might take a little longer, especially with Christmas coming up.
>
> For those who celebrate: happy early Christmas! 🎄 And for those who don't, I hope you have an amazing week.
>
> Thank you all for the support—it means so much! ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 2 : Adora

"Hello?" Bow waved a hand in front of Adora's gray eyes. "Earth to Adora? Are you there?"

Adora blinked, trying to shake off the woozy feeling creeping over her. The restaurant walls felt like they were closing in, shrinking more with each passing second. Her mouth was dry, her throat raw, like sandpaper scraping as she swallowed. But none of that compared to the tight knot in her stomach, a knot so twisted it defied any attempt to unravel it. Her hands trembled slightly, betraying the turmoil inside her.

"Dor? Are you good?"

Glimmer's voice cut through the haze, but her face was blurred, out of focus.

How could Catra be here? Adora's mind raced, fragments of thought spiraling out of control. *Why would she be here? She hated school—so why the hell would she voluntarily sign up for more?*

She stared down at her drink, the glass cold and solid in her hands. Leaving wasn't an option. One, it would be rude with the band about to perform. Two, it would mean admitting defeat, and her pride had already taken enough hits tonight. There was no way it could survive another.

"Adora?"

Bow's voice brought her back again, grounding her.

"What? Yeah, I'm fine," she stammered, forcing a smile that didn't reach her eyes.

Glimmer frowned, concern etched into her face, while Bow gave her a slow, cautious nod.

"Really, guys," Adora insisted, her voice steadier now. "I'm fine. I just need another drink."

Glimmer rolled her eyes as Bow flagged down a waitress. Adora took the opportunity to focus on the stage. The band was setting up—plugging in cables, tuning instruments. Her eyes followed Entrapta, the bassist, as she grabbed a bottle of water from a stool and took a quick sip.

Then her gaze shifted. Scorpia stood off to the side, laughing at something. And next to her—*her*—was Catra.

Scorpia must've cracked a joke because Catra shook her head in mock exasperation, a smirk tugging at her lips. Adora's stomach tightened. She hadn't seen that smirk in years.

A flicker of jealousy burned through her as she watched Catra and Scorpia interact. Once, she'd been the one at Catra's side. Her "second in command,". But that was another lifetime, one she couldn't afford to dwell on.

How could I feel jealous over someone who isn't even mine anymore?

"I'm gonna get a drink," Adora said abruptly, standing before either Glimmer or Bow could protest.

She weaved through the tables, murmuring polite apologies as she went. The bar was busy, but Adora was determined to feel the effects of alcohol as quickly as possible. Scanning the menu, she settled on a Long Island iced tea.

Adora leaned against the counter, staring at the neon lights that bathed the bar in shades of blue, pink, and green. The Grill had an old-school charm—simple, a little worn, but welcoming. Thankfully, it was a non-smoking establishment. The smell of cigarettes was something she'd grown to loathe, a reminder of her childhood and the secrets her parents hid behind perfect smiles and polished facades.

Her drink arrived, but before she could reach for her wallet, the bartender raised a hand.

"No charge. Someone covered it."

"What?" Adora blinked, confused.

The bartender gestured over his shoulder. "The brunette. She said you'd need it. Also mentioned how gross Long Islands are and said they're not really your style."

She followed the direction of his gesture, but the spot was empty.

Of course, she thought, her stomach tightening again. She turned back toward her table, drink in hand, only to bump into someone.

“Sorry—”

“Hey, Adora.”

The voice was unmistakable. Adora froze, slowly looking up to meet the one face she hadn’t been ready to see tonight.

“Catra,” she said, her voice soft, unsure. “Hey.”

Catra stood there in the neon glow, calm and composed. Adora, meanwhile, felt like she’d been knocked off balance. It had been years, but Catra was so familiar and yet so different. Her hair was longer, her curls more defined, her face sharper, more mature. And her eyes—one blue, one pale green—stared back at Adora, unblinking.

Adora opened her mouth to speak, but the words caught in her throat. After a few agonizing seconds of silence, she forced herself to say something. Anything.

“What are you doing here?”

The brunette raised an eyebrow, the defiance in her expression evident. “Performing. And since when did you start drinking Long Islands?”

Adora felt someone bump into her back as they passed, nearly spilling her drink in the process. “I mean, I’ve had them before,” she said, recalling a blurry memory from her junior year of college when one Long Island had her giggling uncontrollably. She straightened herself. “I meant, in Cambridge.”

The brunette smirked, her expression teetering on the edge of amusement and indifference. “Didn’t you hear? I’m going to school here. The gigs help with tuition.” She motioned to the stage behind her.

Adora laughed nervously, staring at her drink instead of meeting those piercing eyes. Looking at Catra now, after nearly five years, felt like too much. Too raw. “Why Harvard?”

It was an innocent question, one meant to ask about her studies, her ambitions—maybe even why she'd chosen this city of all places. But hidden beneath those words, unspoken and fragile, lay the question Adora wouldn't dare voice: Did you know I was here?

Catra's expression shifted sharply, her smirk replaced by a pointed glare. "What, like it was hard? You didn't think I could do it?"

"No!" Adora stammered, the words catching in her throat. "That's not what I meant. I—"

"Save it." Catra crossed her arms, her voice laced with disdain. "You left, Adora. You left everything and everyone to run off to your fancy school. But here's the thing: it's not that hard. And unlike you, I didn't need Mommy and Daddy's money to do it."

Adora flinched at the words, their accuracy cutting deeper than Catra could have known. Catra didn't know it wasn't Adora's choice. Or maybe she did and aimed for the wound anyway. Either way, it stung.

"I'm sorry," Adora whispered, her eyes dropping to the ice in her glass.

Catra scoffed, the sound heavy with bitterness. "Don't. Just don't." She inhaled sharply, holding Adora's gaze one last time. "You haven't changed. Still the same self-righteous asshole I knew."

Adora opened her mouth to respond, to explain, but Catra was already gone. Her retreating figure took with it any hope of reconciliation, leaving Adora standing there with the weight of their history pressing down on her.

Her heart thundered in her chest, each beat echoing in her ears. Without thinking, she turned back to the bar. "Shot of Jameson, please."

The bartender hesitated, glancing at her untouched drink. Still, he poured the shot, sliding it toward her with a knowing nod. Adora tossed it back in one swift motion, the burn in her throat a

welcome distraction. She left a ten under the empty glass and headed back to the table.

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"Took you long enough," Glimmer's voice cut through the noise as Adora slid into her seat.

"No kidding. Twenty minutes for a drink?" Bow teased, glancing at her nearly full glass.

Adora barely registered their words. Her mind was a whirlwind of memories, feelings, and the sharp sting of her confrontation with Catra.

"It's her," she murmured, lifting her drink and taking a long gulp.

"Who?" Glimmer's voice carried a mix of curiosity and concern as she watched Adora down the liquor.

"Catra. From UCLA."

Glimmer didn't respond. Maybe it was the band starting up again, or maybe it was the countless nights she'd spent comforting Adora over this very woman. Either way, Adora was grateful for the silence.

Her gaze drifted to the stage, to Catra. She watched her, mesmerized, until the lyrics of the song began to sink in, each word twisting the knife a little deeper.

"Was it worth it? Are you proud? Did you really think that I'd forgive you now? What does she give you that I couldn't? If you'd asked me, well, I would've. Hope it's weighing on your conscience. Might be brutal, but it's honest."

The song ended, as did her drink—and with it, any shred of hope she'd carried into the night. Adora had always been the type to assume the worst. If she imagined the worst-case scenario, she could prepare herself, plan for it, maybe even soften the blow

when it came. So who could blame her for immediately assuming the song was about her?

She was exhausted, the dizzy haze from the alcohol doing little to dull the ache in her chest. It hurt. Even in her state, her mind spiraled, trying to piece it together: Catra would never forgive her —not for what she'd done. And now, Adora would have to live with the consequences of her own actions.

When she glanced at Glimmer and Bow, she found them already watching her. Their matching expressions of sympathy and concern only made the weight in her chest sink deeper.

"I want to go home," she muttered.

They shot to their feet, the sudden movement making her sway even more. Or maybe it was the alcohol finally catching up to her. She couldn't care less about the drink's effects or the fact that they'd only been at the bar for barely two hours. She was done.

"Yeah, yeah, I'll call the Uber," Glimmer said quickly, giving Bow a pointed look before spinning around, phone already in hand.

"You wanna wait in the lobby? It's quieter there," Bow offered, his voice calm and steady.

Adora nodded and followed, doing her best to keep her blurry eyes focused on Bow's back as they wove through the crowd. Her legs felt like jelly, unsteady with every step, but Bow's steady presence kept her grounded. After what felt like an eternity, they finally reached the lobby. The moment they did, Adora practically collapsed onto one of the cushioned benches, her head tilting back as she tried to catch her breath.

She wasn't sure why, but her cheeks were wet, droplets of water sliding down her face. Frowning, she looked up at the ceiling, then over at Bow. He was staring at her with unmistakable concern.

Why does he look so worried? she wondered, her tangled thoughts looping around themselves. *His name is literally Bow.*

That's such a cool name—what does he even have to be concerned about?

"Bow," she mumbled, her voice slow and thick, "I think the ceiling is crying."

The words sounded sluggish to her own ears, like they were wading through syrup. Everything felt slow, her body heavy and her thoughts lighter than air.

Bow didn't answer right away. Instead, he stepped closer and crouched in front of her. Gently, he wiped a tear from her cheek with the pad of his thumb, his expression soft but tinged with sadness.

Adora let out a snort-laugh, the sound mangled and unexpected, but somehow it broke through the fog. "Thanks," she muttered, her lips curving into a faint, lopsided smile.

The Uber arrived quickly. The ride was a blur of garbled words and half-coherent confessions—how she couldn't believe Catra had been there, how much she must have hurt her when she left, and how desperately she wished she could go back in time and fix everything.

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Adora managed to wake up at a decent hour, with just enough time to shower, force down a bitter cup of coffee, and take three Tylenol to dull the pounding in her head. She was annoyed with herself. Drinking enough to actually have fun only to end the night early, wake up hungover, and still feel awful? Definitely not worth it.

Her first class started at ten, and by eight, she had plenty of time to prepare. She double-checked her books and laptop, then triple-checked them because old habits died hard. Thirty minutes later, her mother's ever-meticulous planning came to mind. Years of being driven to campus and forced to walk the exact route to her building had drilled efficiency into her routine. Adora sighed. You'd

think her parents would back off now that she was twenty-two, but no. If anything, they'd only tightened their grip once they realized their "perfect daughter" was chasing *their* dreams, not hers.

Adora eyed the outfit hanging in the living room window. It wasn't her. Too uptight. She didn't mind wearing it, but she'd much prefer sweats and not having to carry a gym bag everywhere. Begrudgingly, she grabbed the clothes, pulled them on, and fiddled with the shirt collar until it sat just right.

Her reflection stared back from the mirror: hair damp and slightly wavy from her shower, brushing her upper back. It had grown a bit in the last year. She tied it up, pulling at loose strands until she finally gave up and let it be.

Her black backpack was packed with her books and laptop. Her gym bag held a change of clothes, tennis shoes, and an energy packet. She checked the time. Barely nine.

Annoyed, Adora grabbed a water bottle and perched on the kitchen counter. She mentally recited her schedule, her thoughts eventually drifting to her phone.

Scrolling through Spotify, she searched for *Fading Lines* but came up empty. On YouTube, a few recent videos popped up—covers, mostly. No original songs. One video caught her eye, and she clicked it. The band was good, as always. Her gaze lingered on a certain brunette.

The more she searched, the more questions popped up. The band had been in California until a few months ago, when they moved to Cambridge. Catra had never mentioned they'd all followed her to grad school. Why?

Adora snapped out of her thoughts, shut off her phone, and gathered her bags. Phone, keys, wallet—all there. She locked the apartment door and headed for the elevator.

A polite smile to the receptionist, a left turn instead of heading for the garage, and she found her car after a few minutes. Tossing her bags into the passenger seat, she started the car. Against her better judgment, she queued up *Fading Lines* and hit play.

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The crisp morning air greeted her as she walked to class. She slipped in her AirPods and took a deep breath, the earthy smell of damp wood and soil filling her lungs. Over time, she'd come to love it.

She smiled at familiar faces, waving to a few overly enthusiastic classmates. When she reached her building, she tugged at the door handle. Nothing.

She tried again.

"It's a push," a voice said. "Here."

Adora turned to see a brunette standing behind her. The girl was a few inches shorter and stepped past her with a small smile, pushing the door open with ease. Apparently, Adora had yet to master the ancient art of opening doors.

"They should really put up signs," the brunette said, her tone light and teasing.

Adora chuckled, walking through the now-open door. There was something vaguely familiar about the girl, though she couldn't quite place it.

"No kidding," Adora replied. "They should know there are wild blondes roaming around campus."

The brunette grinned, clarifying the joke with a quick laugh. They ascended the stairs together, the sound of their footsteps echoing in the enclosed space.

“What class are you headed to?” Adora asked, breaking the brief silence.

“Ethics and Social Justice. You?” the brunette responded, glancing at her.

“Philosophy of Law,” Adora replied, grimacing as she stumbled slightly over the word “Philosophy.” No matter how much she practiced, she always seemed to trip over it.

“Ah, no kidding. My friend’s in that class. I think she came early to talk to the professor,” the girl said casually.

Adora smiled. “Small world. I’m Adora, by the way.”

The brunette hesitated for a moment, her eyebrows furrowing in confusion before relaxing. “Uh, Lonnie. Hope you enjoy class,” she said quickly, offering a small wave as she pushed open the door to the fourth floor and disappeared into the hallway.

Adora stood there for a moment, her mind racing. *Lonnie? Why does that name sound so familiar?* Shaking her head, she climbed the last flight of stairs and stepped into the fifth-floor hallway.

As she walked, she pulled out her phone to check the time and confirm the classroom number. The screen lit up: 9:42.

“Room 514,” she mumbled, scanning the doors as she passed them.

When she finally reached the room, she paused to take it in. The classroom was set up in a tiered, semicircular design, with each level descending toward the front. A large whiteboard loomed behind a podium at the center of the room. A few students were already seated, their murmured conversations filling the space.

Adora chose a seat two rows from the front and began unpacking her things, placing her laptop on the desk in front of her. As she opened it, her mind wandered back to Lonnie.

Why does her name feel like a puzzle piece I'm supposed to remember?

With a soft sigh, Adora pushed the thought aside and focused on preparing for class. She pulled out her phone and saw a text from her mom asking if she'd made it on time. Of course, she'd be checking. Adora rolled her eyes as she typed a quick response.

Over the next ten minutes, more and more students flooded in, their voices filling the room. Adora scrolled through some basketball plays on her laptop, trying to tune out the chatter. Eventually, the door at the front of the room opened, and in walked the professor.

Adora glanced up from her screen. The professor was younger than she had expected—brown hair neatly braided, with bangs framing her face. She was tall, lean, and carried herself with an energy that felt more youthful than authoritative.

As the class quieted down, Adora shut her laptop, erring on the side of caution. She'd learned the hard way that some professors were staunchly anti-technology. Better to play it safe than risk a lecture on day one.

Professor Light set her bags down behind the podium and smiled warmly at the room. "Well, look at you guys," she began. "Going for round two, I see."

The room chuckled softly, and Adora allowed herself a small smile.

"Well, as I'm sure most of you know," Light continued, shuffling through some papers, "I'm Professor Light. Welcome to Philosophy of Law." She handed a stack of papers to the front row. "Please pass these around. This is your syllabus. There's also a digital copy on the course website. Be sure to read it thoroughly because this class is going to be a little different from the usual."

Adora took a syllabus from the stack and passed it along.

"If you're wondering what Philosophy of Law is, let me give you the quick version. In this class, we'll explore the theoretical and foundational aspects of the law—its nature, its principles, and how it intersects with moral, ethical, and political issues." Light took a dramatic breath, earning a few giggles from the class. "Or, in simpler terms, we're going to figure out *why* we have laws and *how* to make and follow them."

Adora scanned the syllabus, and her heart sank. Unlike the usual breakdown of quizzes, assignments, and exams, there were only two grades listed. Two grades. If she bombed one, she'd fail the entire class.

"I can tell by some of your faces that you've started reading the syllabus," Light said with a knowing smile. "Let me ease your worries. This project will be done in partners. So before you all start panicking, let me explain."

Adora's stomach twisted. She didn't know anyone in the class, let alone someone she could trust to be a good partner.

"The project, *Justice vs. Morality,* will make up 35% of your grade," Light explained. "Attendance is another 15%, and your final—split between a presentation of your project and a comprehensive exam—will account for 45%." She paused, letting the weight of her words sink in. "This is not college anymore. You're here to learn, to excel, to become leaders in your field. Not just to check a box on a bachelor's degree."

A student raised his hand. "You said the project would be in pairs. How will partners be chosen?"

"No need to worry about that," Light said, picking up another stack of papers. "I've already assigned them based on your majors and areas of study. You'll analyze a landmark legal case, examining it through both a historical and philosophical lens. Each pair will present opposing perspectives and explore the interplay between justice and morality."

Adora's mind raced. She didn't even know where to start brainstorming cases, let alone with someone she didn't know. She scribbled some ideas in her notebook—*Roe v. Wade, Brown v. Board of Education, Nuremberg Trials*—anything that might fit the project's requirements.

Light began reading off pairs, and students shifted seats to join their assigned partners.

"Adora Gray and Catra Weaver," Light announced.

Adora froze. Her heart sank as her gaze darted to the back of the room. Sure enough, Catra was sitting there, smirking, her fingers tapping rhythmically on her chin. Adora's stomach churned. *This has to be a mistake.*

She gathered her things and approached the professor. "Um, Professor Light?"

"Yes?" Light asked, tilting her head.

"I'm Adora Gray, and… I'm not sure my partner will want to work with me because of, uh, past issues. Is there any way I could switch?"

Light gave her a small, apologetic smile. "I'm sorry, Adora. The pairs were carefully chosen based on compatibility."

"Are you making me sound difficult, Adora? I'm hurt."

Adora flinched at the voice behind her and turned to see Catra standing there, arms crossed and a smug grin plastered on her face.

"That's not what I said," Adora replied, forcing a polite smile.

"You're right," Catra said, placing a hand on Adora's shoulder. Adora stiffened under the touch. "You said you weren't *one hundred percent sure* I'd want to work with you." Catra flicked

Adora’s ponytail with a teasing smirk. “Why wouldn’t I want to work with my long-lost best friend?”

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was a ride! Adora getting drunk only to go home and sleep it off... Don’t worry, y’all will get some proper drunk Adora content soon. 😉

Also, THAT SONG DESTROYS ME. It’s Word Vomit by Kenzie—please go listen to it, OMG! On another note, I’ve made a playlist for the book, along with one for the songs I feel like the band would play. If y’all want me to share it here, just let me know! 🎶

So… y’all notice how I threw those partners in early? LMAO, same—I wasn’t about to let this story drag out.

Any guesses on who Professor Light is? 👀

ANYWAY, I hope you all have an amazing day! Thank you for the support and kindness—it really means a lot. ❤️

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Well, hello again. Chapter 3. This one stung a bit. I had three songs on repeat: Do I Ever Cross Your Mind by Sombr, Flowers by Lauren Spencer Smith, and About You by The 1975. That pretty much sums up this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 3: Adora

"Why wouldn't I want to work with my long-lost best friend?"

Adora froze, her nails digging into her palms as she mentally cringed at the situation unfolding before her. Of course, Catra had been standing right there. After last night, their already fractured relationship had somehow managed to reach new depths. Adora didn't think it was possible for things to get worse between them, but here she was—hitting metaphorical bedrock.

And maybe, she thought grimly, literally digging her own grave.

Exhaling sharply, Adora unclenched her fists and forced herself to glance at Catra. She braced herself for the undoubtedly smug expression that was likely plastered across the brunette's face. Instead, she kept her focus on the worn brown carpet beneath her shoes, willing herself to stay calm.

Maybe if I pretend she's not here, she'll disappear, Adora thought sarcastically.

The low hum of chatter filled the room as classmates worked out the final details for their semester-long projects. Some were gathering their things to leave, while others stayed to brainstorm. Meanwhile, Adora remained rooted in place, her feet glued to the floor.

“Adora,” Catra drawled, her voice smooth and infuriating. “Are you going to stand there looking like an idiot, or are we actually going to figure this out?”

Adora inhaled deeply and tilted her head toward the ceiling before finally turning to meet Catra’s mismatched eyes. Those eyes. Adora couldn’t help but wonder why Catra had decided to wear contact lenses that gave her heterochromia. Was it for the band? A fashion choice? Maybe she thought it suited her better? Hell, for all Adora knew, it was a misordered prescription. Whatever the reason, it worked for her.

Catra’s smug expression faltered, giving way to irritation. “Adora?” she prompted, raising an eyebrow while tapping her ring finger against her thumb in a slow rhythm.

“Right,” Adora muttered, snapping out of her thoughts. “Where do you want to sit?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Not in the front, Miss Perfect.”

Adora licked her lips. “I don’t sit in the very front.”

“What?” Catra tossed the response over her shoulder as she headed up the steps toward her usual spot.

“Nothing,” Adora mumbled under her breath, following her begrudgingly.

The classroom felt emptier now as more students finalized their topics and filed out. The silence only seemed to intensify the tension between them. Adora trailed behind, her eyes fixed on the gentle bounce of Catra’s curls.

Catra plopped into her chair with a dramatic sigh, leaning back like she owned the place. Arms crossed and eyebrow raised, she looked at Adora expectantly.

“Well?” Catra’s voice was sharp, laced with amusement. “I’m assuming you’ve already planned this thing out?”

Adora clenched her jaw, willing herself to let the jab slide. She pulled out her notebook and laptop, typing "morality vs. justice cases" into the search bar. Before Adora could dive into the results, a tap on her shoulder made her flinch. She turned, meeting Catra's mismatched gaze. Instead of delivering another snide remark, Catra merely pointed toward the board.

Adora followed her finger to a list of already-taken cases. *Roe v. Wade* was right at the top. Of course, it was—Google's first suggestion.

"Got it. Thanks," Adora muttered, scrolling through the search results. To her frustration, most of the cases listed online were already up on the board. She decided to brainstorm instead. "We could do *United States v. Windsor*, or *Miranda v. Arizona*, or—"

"Boring," Catra interrupted, inspecting her nails as she tipped her chair back on two legs.

Adora blinked, caught off guard. "Excuse me?"

"You heard me," Catra said, her mismatched eyes gleaming with amusement. "Do you really want to do the most basic presentation in the class? Honestly, I'm surprised you managed to beat the ones already on the board. You did go to Harvard, after all."

Adora felt heat rise to her ears as her patience snapped. She leaned forward, slamming her palm against the side of Catra's chair, forcing it back onto all four legs. Catra's eyes widened briefly before her usual smirk returned.

"This isn't about being 'basic,'" Adora hissed through gritted teeth. "It's about getting a good grade. In case you weren't paying attention—which, let's be honest, you probably weren't—this project is worth almost half of our grade."

Catra's smirk only widened, like she was delighted to have struck a nerve. "Right, because you're so exciting, aren't you?" she teased, leaning in until their faces were inches apart. "Tell me,

Adora, do you plan your grocery list with the same enthusiasm, or do Mommy and Daddy do that for you?"

Adora glared, her grip tightening on the chair's edge before she exhaled and leaned back. "Do you ever take anything seriously?"

Catra shrugged nonchalantly. "Not when I don't have to."

Silence stretched between them, the tension thick and stifling. Adora tried to focus on the page in front of her, willing the throbbing in her temples to subside.

"Fine," she said finally, breaking the stalemate. "If you have a better idea, let's hear it."

Catra hummed thoughtfully, tapping out a rhythm on the table. Adora was about to repeat herself when Catra spoke. "How about *Loving v. Virginia*? It's less obvious, not on the board, and it might actually keep me awake."

Adora blinked, surprised. For once, Catra's suggestion wasn't just productive—it was actually good. She mentally reviewed the case: *Loving v. Virginia*, tackled morality versus justice on the subject of interracial marriage, balancing the right to love against outdated laws. The case's outcome was a powerful message of progress and change.

"Yeah," Adora said, jotting notes into her notebook. "That's actually a good one."

Catra's smirk softened into a brief, genuine smile. "See? I'm not completely useless."

Adora rolled her eyes, fighting back a small laugh. "You're not useless. Just… difficult. Most of the time."

The words slipped out before she could stop them, and her cheeks burned as she realized what she'd said. Before Catra could respond, Adora blurted, "I'll put together some preliminary research tonight."

"Of course you will," Catra said as she stood. "That's what you do—plan, research, stress yourself out, then plan some more." She gave Adora a once-over, her expression softening into something almost nostalgic. "…While I do my thing."

Adora frowned, unsure how to respond as she watched Catra gather her things. She was about to ask when they should meet again when Catra spoke.

"Library. Tonight at four. I have rehearsal at eight, so don't be late." With that, she turned and strode toward the door. "See you tonight, partner."

The door clicked shut, and Adora slumped against the desk, letting out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding.

This is going to be a disaster.

Adora sat in the empty classroom for a while, part of her yearning for the calm after the storm. Her notes on *Loving v. Virginia* sat in front of her, but her eyes had lost the ability to focus. The case was substantial—she knew that. But it wasn't just the project that had her mind spiraling. It was the way Catra's facade seemed to crack when she mentioned their past, and for the first time since Adora had seen her, it didn't look like anger when she remembered.

Sure, part of Adora wished she could erase the past—it would be so much easier to forget it all. The awkwardness, the resentment, the way their friendship shattered like glass when she left. But no matter how many times she tried to move past it, there was always something pulling her back. Even before Catra came back into her life, the good parts of their relationship always seemed to surface, flooding Adora's memories like the street near her apartment after it rained—steady at first, but the more she dwelled on the past, the heavier the stream became. It felt like there was an invisible thread tying her to it—loose enough to let her think it had broken off, but every time she tried to leave, it yanked her back.

She rubbed her temples as she fell back into her chair, glancing at the watch on her wrist. It was barely eleven. She had a full day ahead but, surprisingly, no more classes. Practice was at twelve-thirty, lasting until three-thirty—leaving no room for a break between the gym and the library. She'd have to find time to research the project.

Guess that's what I'll do while I wait, she thought to herself.

Something told her the real challenge wouldn't be a busy day. No. It would be surviving a few hours at the library with Catra—alone.

Adora glanced at the clock again. She was still sitting in the quiet classroom, and the silence was more suffocating than ever. With a deep breath, she forced herself to stand and gather her things. Practice was next on her list. She was grateful for the upcoming distraction.

As she exited the building, she couldn't help but let her mind wander. She had an hour and a half before practice and could use that time to research something—maybe even manage to get her mind off the past for the first time in the last twenty-four hours.

Adora made her way across campus to the parking lot where her car was parked. This past lifeline had a strange way of pulling her back because as soon as her mind stopped overthinking her meeting, it instantly went to her parents. Adora was the girl who had to perform, to be the best, to never, ever fail. She learned pretty early on that nothing she could ever do would be enough—not for them, at least. But that didn't stop her from trying. If she were worth only what she could give, then there wouldn't be anything left of her until it was enough.

Catra unknowingly lifted a weight off Adora's chest back at UCLA. That heavy anchor of expectations and the fear of disappointing the only people who had chosen her was lifted in that dorm room in California. Somehow, a girl with wild, curly brown hair, piercing blue eyes, and a guitar slung across her back managed to unravel the carefully constructed world of overachiever Adora. She was a

storm that ripped through the polished facade, making Adora question what it meant to live for herself rather than for the expectations of others.

In the end, it wasn't this girl's music that caught Adora off guard. It was the way her mind began to wander, thinking that maybe—just maybe—she could exist outside of the plans someone else had for her.

Her parents snuffed out that flame before it could catch, sensing the smoke as the oxygen began to feed it. It was easier for Adora to fall back into line than to leap across that gap. The thought of disappointing them—of being anything less than what they'd imagined—terrified her. So she buried it, buried everything so deep inside, even knowing that the blonde would never let herself think of the future she could have had had she only *stayed.*

Catra was *forbidden,* and the sad part was, Adora couldn't tell if those were her own words in her mind, or her parents'.

Adora shook her head, forcing herself to focus on the present. Thoughts of her parents, of Catra, and of all this mess had to wait. She wouldn't let them consume her. She had something that was hers, something that required her full attention.

As the blonde made her way to her car and began driving, she couldn't help but speed. Suddenly, the anticipation of practice had never felt better. Coaching was her safe space—something she had built for herself, something she had failed at before and still managed to survive, giving her a potential future because of it. It was a lifeline and one she intended to keep safe.

The familiar scent of polished wood and faint sweat hit Adora the moment she stepped into the gym. The rhythmic echo of basketballs bouncing off the court and the sharp squeak of sneakers against the floor filled the air, grounding her in the present. She let out a slow breath, feeling relaxed for the first time in a while.

This was her safe space; somewhere she could finally find a second to breathe.

Adora stood in the entrance to the gym for a split second, letting herself focus back in before putting on her game face.

"Reyes says that is not happening today."

Adora's gaze snapped to the baseline, where the head coach, Conner Reyes, stood with his ever-present clipboard in hand. He wore his signature smirk, shaking his head as he watched one of the players take a shot—and miss by a mile.

"Always welcoming that positive attitude, Coach!" Adora called out down the court, her tone laced with amusement.

Conner chuckled, turning toward her. "You know me– gotta keep them humble."

Adora rolled her eyes as she walked along the baseline of the court. "You ever thought about becoming a motivational speaker? I am sure there is a Ted Talk slot primed and ready for you."

He chuckled, tucking the clipboard under his arm. "I'll consider it when I'm making the real big bucks. For now, I'll crush dreams for minimum wage."

Adora raised an eyebrow. "The big bucks? You're a coach—how much are you really getting paid, C.R.?"

He grinned, his playful attitude matching his sarcastic charm. "More than the janitor, that's for sure."

Her laugh came quickly, surprising her. Conner had a way of cutting through the heaviness, even on her worst days. He'd been there from the start, watching her grow as both a player and a coach. He'd recommended her for the position, though he'd never admit it outright. She appreciated him for that—and for the way he always seemed to know when she needed a distraction.

"You all good?" He asked, his voice dropping to a more serious tone.

"Yeah," Adora said, catching a ball off a rebound. "Just busier than I thought I'd be."

He nodded, not pushing her to elaborate. That was another thing she liked about Conner—he knew when to back off.

"Good," he said, his tone lightening again. "Because Reyes says slacking is definitely not happening today."

Adora snorted, tossing the ball toward a nearby rack. "Message received, Coach."

She stood by the sidelines, watching the players warm up, finally allowing herself to breathe for the first time all day. For a while, she just existed at the moment, tossing out a few playful jabs whenever someone missed a shot. Here, there was no need to overanalyze her parents, Catra, or her grades. Here, she didn't have to be perfect or have all the answers. Sometimes, the blonde wished she could slip into someone else's mind, just for a while. But that wasn't possible. Right now, all she needed was to be Coach Adora—and for now, that was more than enough.

Catra

Catra lay sprawled out across her couch, the dim lights in her apartment casting shadows along the walls. She hated overhead lighting; it always triggered waves of headaches coursing through her. The silence in the room felt like a physical weight pressing down on her. Usually, she welcomed it. Living with three bandmates meant constant noise—strumming, singing, and general chaos. But tonight, the stillness was suffocating.

She stared up at the ceiling, her thoughts a tangled mess.

It had been a while since she'd left campus. It was a while since she'd walked out of that class—the class she'd just *coincidentally* had with Adora. The moment Catra spotted the blonde ponytail in

the front row, she thought it was some sick joke. What were the odds? The two of them set up in the same class *and* semester-long partners?

Catra wanted absolutely nothing to do with Miss Perfect Ponytail. Seeing Adora at the bar, though—well, that was something she could laugh about. In a few years, she'd probably look back and chuckle at how, after all this time, she'd run into Adora in some random college bar. But it didn't change the fact that she was still so perfect. It didn't make Catra feel any less furious at the blonde.

Why did it have to be her?

Catra forced herself to sit up, dragging her hands down her face in frustration. Adora was the last person she ever wanted to see, yet there she was—effortlessly gliding through the bar, all smiles and ease. Catra ran her fingers through her curls, only to get them hopelessly tangled. She couldn't think about her. She was too perfect, too... safe. Meanwhile, Catra was still stuck—stuck back in her dorm room at UCLA, stuck in her old mindset. And Adora? Adora had moved on. Left. While Catra was still angry, bitter, and alone.

The memories hadn't stopped since the last time she saw her at the bar. Hell, they hadn't stopped since Adora left five years ago. They kept coming back, unbidden, and with each one, Catra's jaw tightened. The two of them hadn't talked in years, yet Adora had the audacity to flirt with her. Granted, Catra had started it before she even realized who the woman was. Seeing Adora with her hair down—that was a first.

She shouldn't feel anything. She should feel indifferent. Feeling indifferent was a hell of a lot easier than facing the sting of old wounds reopening.

"She doesn't matter," Catra muttered aloud, trying to make herself believe it. She couldn't lie to herself in her mind, but saying the words out loud made it feel a little bit more believable.

But even as she said it, the words felt hollow. *She doesn't matter.* Catra clenched her fist, letting her grown-out nails dig into her palms. Maybe if she kept repeating it, the words would start to stick. She wouldn't let herself go back to that place—the place where her chest ached every time she thought of Adora.

She didn't care why the blonde had left. She didn't care what had happened. She didn't care about her. *She didn't.*

The room felt smaller now. The silence pressed in on her, suffocating, not helping the cramped space. She pulled out her notebook, trying to force out some lyrics, some release. But instead, her thoughts spiraled, each one pulling her back to UCLA—back before it all fell apart.

How could I have been so stupid?

This wasn't the first time she'd spent hours of her life thinking about Adora. What was the point? What had Adora really wanted from her? All that time, all those months, only for it to disappear.

She exhaled loudly, letting her frustration spill out of her. *Why am I still so angry?*

It wasn't just the blonde's perfect hair or the way everything seemed to be handed to her on a golden platter. It was the fact that Catra couldn't forget her, no matter what she did. Adora's smile, her blue eyes—eyes that Catra had once thought saw straight through her.

She's just a person—someone I used to know.

But Catra didn't buy it. Adora was never just anything. She was everything.

She wanted to punch the wall and claw at the ceiling. Anything to rid herself of the thoughts. But all she could do was sit there, replaying the past over and over in her mind like a broken record. The same thoughts, the same questions she'd never found answers to.

Do I ever cross your mind?

Why did you leave?

Why did I let you?

Why wasn't I enough for you?

Catra would never admit out loud that she wasn't angry at Adora for leaving—at least, not entirely. She was furious at herself for still caring.

It was easier to be mad—easier to stay angry—than to admit how much she missed Adora and how much she still needed her.

Chapter End Notes

> HEHE, Catra POV! Roll with it, because it might be a couple of chapters before we get back into her head again. HOW ARE WE FEELINGGGGG? I hope it's good, because I'm kinda nervous I'm doing this horribly, lol. Anywho, bye for now! Again, thanks for all the love and support. See you all soon!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> "Time does not heal all wounds. If it did, there would be no unresolved grief and no hurt from long ago that still upsets you from time to time. Pain that is not faced does not go away; it stays inside and festers." — Susan J. Elliott, Getting
>
> I felt like this quote really fits these two.
>
> Also, I had Exile by Taylor Swift and You Don't Get Me by Lana Del Rey blasting on repeat while writing this chapter—definitely set the mood!
>
> Hello again! Sorry this chapter took a bit longer to post. I had a family member visiting and wanted to spend time with them. A quick heads-up: I start college in a week (cue the tears). I'm a biochem major, so it's going to be a lot of work! I started this fic over Christmas break when I had plenty of free time, but once college kicks in, I'll probably settle into a posting schedule—maybe once or twice a week, depending on how busy I am.
>
> Thanks so much for reading and sticking with me! <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 4 : Adora

Adora adjusted the strap of her backpack and swiped her card at the library door. The little red light blinked green with a soft ding, and the lock clicked open. She pushed the door open, her sneakers squeaking against the polished floor as she stepped inside. The familiar smell of old books and lemony cleaner hit her, a scent she had spent way too much time getting used to. Normally, it was comforting. Today, though, she wasn't in the mood to care.

She glanced at her phone. **3:50 p.m.** Ten minutes early—right on schedule. Not because she was obsessively punctual (okay, maybe she was), but because the idea of Catra beating her here, sitting there with that smug look, was enough to make her rush over. She adjusted her bag, tugging at the hem of her shirt like it might somehow make her outfit less... not.

She hadn't bothered changing back into what her mom would call "proper clothes" after practice. Instead, she'd gone with her backup—gray gym shorts, a black T-shirt, and sneakers. Functional. Easy. She didn't care what Catra thought anyway, right? But standing here, she couldn't shake the nagging feeling that she looked out of place.

The library stretched across three floors, each with its own vibe. The first was for chatter—study groups huddled in cubicles along the walls, laptops clacking away at long tables in the middle. The second floor was quieter, whisper-only territory, with shelves crammed full of books, desks and few study rooms for the more focused types. And then there was the third floor, the "absolutely-no-talking-or-I'll-stare-daggers-at-you" floor. Adora had always liked the no-talking floor best. She wondered if she'd need it after this meeting.

Adora made her way up to the second floor, her shoes squeaking with every step. She winced at the sound. As much as she wished she could head straight to the third floor, she knew it wasn't practical for a project meeting. The second floor was a safer option—quiet enough to work, but not so strict that they couldn't talk, as long as it didn't escalate into a screaming match.

Adora hoped Catra would use some common sense and head to the second floor when she inevitably arrived. They'd have to exchange phone numbers again. Adora wondered if Catra still had the same one. She wouldn't know. Old memories flooded back into her head as she climbed the stairs.

The first few days after she left, her phone had been bombarded with notifications from Catra—missed calls, voicemails, texts, all

asking the same questions: Where are you? Are you okay? What happened? After a couple of weeks, the concern in Catra's voice turned to anger. *Why won't you just answer me? You couldn't even say goodbye? Do you know what it's like to come back to the dorm and find all your stuff gone?*

Adora felt every word like a knife to her chest, until it became too much. At first, she just muted Catra's notifications. She'd told herself she'd eventually reach out to explain—tell Catra what had happened. But then the calls stopped, and Adora couldn't bring herself to explain why she had to move, or what had happened with her parents, or what they had found out. Hell, she was barely keeping herself afloat. How could she try to salvage whatever she had with Catra when she herself was barely breathing?

Adora finally made her way to the second floor, her mind a whirlwind of thoughts. How was she supposed to act? Normal? What *was* their normal? It had been less than a day, and she'd somehow managed to piss off Catra more than once. How were they supposed to get anything done?

Her gaze scanned the floor, landing on the bookshelves lining the walls and the scattered tables. She decided on a spot near the windows. At least there, she could distract herself with the people and greenery outside if things took a turn for the worse. Dropping her bag into one of the chairs, she sat down and began unpacking her laptop and notebooks, doing anything to keep her hands steady.

Every minute felt like an hour. Her phone read 3:58 now, and Catra still hadn't shown up. Typical.

Adora's jaw tightened as she thought to herself. She tried distracting herself by opening her notebook, jotting down some half-formed ideas for their project. Loving v. Virginia. Justice vs. Morality. The right to love. The words felt hollow—almost comical. How was she supposed to focus when Catra could walk in at any moment, most likely turning her world upside down *again*?

As if on cue, soft shuffling from behind her broke her train of thought. She didn't need to look up to know who it was.

"You're early," Catra's voice came, smooth and casual, laced with her signature sarcasm. Adora couldn't detect a hint of nervousness from her.

Adora inhaled deeply, both to calm her nerves and to stop herself from snapping back. She looked up from her notebook to find Catra standing across from her, hands in her pockets.

"And you're late," Adora shot back, her tone surprisingly even.

Catra smirked, sliding into her chair across from Adora. She looked effortlessly cool—her loose black button-up hanging off her frame, sleeves rolled up to the elbows. The top was unbuttoned just enough to reveal a glimpse of her chest tattoos, drawing more attention than Adora cared to admit. The khaki cargo pants hung low on her hips, their baggy fit somehow managing to complement her slender frame.

Adora's gaze lingered a moment too long before she snapped out of it, quickly returning her focus to her notebook. Heat crawled up her neck and face.

Catra had always been attractive. That wasn't a secret. But Adora never quite understood how She could look so effortlessly simple, yet so… Catra.

And then there was the scent again—the one that dredged up old memories. It wrapped around Adora like smoke: warm vanilla, coffee, and something darker, something she couldn't quite place. In another lifetime, that scent had brought her comfort. Now, it felt like a rope pulling her back into something she wasn't sure she could handle.

"Adora." Catra's voice sliced through her thoughts, dripping with mock innocence. "You're staring. Again."

“I am not,” Adora shot back, her voice rising higher than she intended.

Catra raised an eyebrow, leaning forward on the table. “Sure you’re not.” Her lips curved into a smirk as she propped her chin on her hand. “But if you were, I wouldn’t blame you.”

Adora bit the inside of her cheek, scribbling something—anything—into her notebook to keep her hands busy. *Focus*, she scolded herself. *You’re here to work, not… whatever this is.*

“Can we just get to work?” Adora snapped, refusing to meet Catra’s amused gaze. “We don’t have time for distractions. You’ve got rehearsal, remember?”

Catra’s chair squeaked as she leaned back, crossing her arms. Her eyes gleamed with mischief. “Rehearsal? Oh, right. That thing I actually care about.” She stretched her words with a biting tone, clearly enjoying every second of Adora’s mounting frustration.

Adora’s fingers tightened around her pen. “Look, we need to focus on this, okay?” she said, her voice low and controlled. “If you’d just—”

“You’re so wound up, Adora. Honestly, it’s impressive.” Catra’s fingers tapped a rhythmic beat on the table, each tap slicing through the silence. “After all this time, I thought you’d be… looser by now.”

The words stung. Of course, she was wound up. Who wouldn’t be? The last two weeks had been a whirlwind, and now she was sitting across from someone who seemed to know exactly how to push all her buttons. She bit back a retort. She wasn’t here to fight. Not with Catra. Not now.

“If you want to leave, then leave,” Adora said coolly, her gaze fixed on her notebook. “No one’s forcing you to be here.”

For a long moment, the only sound was Catra’s steady breathing. Then, softer this time, Catra spoke. “I’m here, aren’t I?”

Adora's head snapped up. Their eyes met, and the silence between them stretched, thick and heavy. So much unsaid. So much unresolved. Catra's face was unreadable, but just as Adora thought she glimpsed something—vulnerability, maybe—it vanished. A wall slammed into place.

Catra broke the silence, leaning forward again. Her tone was sharp and teasing, but there was an edge beneath it. "So, what's the agenda, boss?"

Adora sighed, dragging a hand through her hair. "We need to break down the case, look at the legal precedents, then—" She paused, feeling Catra's eyes on her like a tangible weight. "We need to do this together. At least at the start. If we don't, it's not going to work. We'll divide the research once we've got a plan."

Catra tilted her head, considering. "Fine, whatever. But don't expect me to do all the work."

Adora's jaw clenched, but she forced herself to focus. "I'll handle the legal precedents," she said. "You can work on the historical context and public reaction."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Sounds like you're giving yourself all the boring stuff."

"I trust myself to get it done," Adora snapped before she could stop herself.

The words hung in the air. Catra blinked, surprise flickering across her face for just a moment before her walls went back up.

"Wow," Catra said, her fingers resuming their tapping. "You really haven't changed, have you?"

Adora huffed. "And you have?"

Catra shrugged, her expression mocking. "Guess you should've stuck around. You might've known."

Adora’s nails dug into her palms. “Listen, we don’t have time for this. If you’re not going to take this seriously—”

“Who says I’m not taking this seriously?” Catra interrupted, her tone sharp now, the teasing replaced by something darker. “Just because I don’t have a stick up my ass doesn’t mean I’m not pulling my weight.”

Adora flinched at the fire in her voice. “That’s not what I said.”

“No, but it’s what you meant,” Catra shot back without missing a beat. “I worked my ass off to get here. Just because I have a life and don’t ditch my friends in the middle of the night doesn’t mean I don’t know how to succeed.”

“That’s not what I meant,” Adora said, her voice rising. “God, you twist everything!”

“Do I?” Catra leaned forward, her gaze piercing. “Or are you just afraid I’m right?”

Adora opened her mouth to respond but stopped herself. She hated how Catra had the ability to unstring every nerve in her body. The brunette always had a knack for stripping away Adora's barriers, leaving her exposed and raw. But the worst part was how much Adora wanted to push back. She wanted to test the limits, to see how far Catra would go if she did.

Instead, she forced herself to focus on the present. “We’re not doing this,” she said firmly. “Not here.”

Catra just inhaled sharply, leaning back in her chair. Her head tilted back as she stared up at the ceiling. “Whatever you say, Ponytail.”

Adora rolled her eyes at the nickname and tried to refocus on her work. But no matter how hard she tried, her thoughts kept drifting back to Catra—to their conversation, to her presence here. She’d gotten into Harvard. Adora had never doubted Catra’s abilities, not for a second. It was true; she should be proud of her.

Without warning, the words spilled out of her mouth before she could stop them. “I never thought you couldn’t do it,” Adora said softly, her voice barely above a whisper. Her eyes stayed glued to the paper in front of her, avoiding Catra’s gaze.

“Do what?” Catra asked, her tone sharp but curious.

“Make it. To Harvard. With the band,” Adora fumbled over the words, struggling to find the right ones before forcing herself to push through. “You’ve always been smart, funny, personable. I wasn’t—” She paused, finally meeting Catra’s mismatched eyes. “I wasn’t surprised you were here at Harvard because I thought you couldn’t do it. I was just... surprised, that’s all. A good surprise, but surprised nonetheless.”

She took a deep breath, her hands gripping the edges of her notebook. “So, I’m sorry—really—if my body language or anything I said came across as condescending. I’ve always known what you’re capable of. I just... didn’t expect to see you here.” Her voice wavered slightly on the last words, but her gaze remained steady.

Catra blinked, her expression faltering for just a moment. Adora saw it—the faint crack in her guarded exterior. But Catra quickly shrugged it off.

“Didn’t think you thought so highly of me,” Catra said, her tone sarcastic but lacking its usual bite. Adora’s eyes caught the way the brunette’s fingers traced idle circles on the table. “Kinda makes me wonder why you disappeared without a word if you care so much.”

Adora’s heart froze. She’d known this would come up, but she still wasn’t prepared when it did.

“I didn’t—” Adora started but stopped herself. She knew getting defensive wouldn’t help. “It wasn’t about you, I promise,” she said, her gaze darting anywhere but at Catra. “I… just had a lot going on.”

“Same old song,” Catra said, leaning back in her chair. “Always a lot going on with you.”

“That’s not fair.” Adora forced herself to meet Catra’s eyes.

“Fair?” Catra’s voice rose sharply, loud enough to draw a few heads from nearby tables. Adora flinched at the attention. Catra, unfazed, raised an eyebrow at the onlookers before continuing, her voice now a low, trembling whisper. “You wanna talk about fair? Because I don’t think ditching your—” she hesitated, swallowing the word, “—me. Ditching me without so much as a text qualifies.”

Adora’s pulse thundered in her ears. Anger flared—not at Catra, but at her parents, who had taken something good, ruined it, and left her to deal with the wreckage.

Her voice dropped, shaking with a mix of anger and desperation. “You think I wanted to leave? To leave *you*? You think it didn’t tear me apart every single day?”

Catra’s eyes narrowed, her laugh sharp and bitter, like a blade cutting through the air. “Tear you apart? Yeah, sure, poor little Miss Perfect. Don’t make me laugh, Adora. If you cared so much, you would’ve stayed. Or at least had the decency to say goodbye.”

Adora felt the sting of Catra’s words, deliberate and painfully accurate. “You don’t know what you’re talking about,” she shot back, her voice rising despite her attempts to stay calm. “You weren’t there. You don’t know what it was like.”

“And whose fault is that?” Catra said flatly, her voice steady, unforgiving. “You didn’t just leave, Adora. You left *me*.”

The words hit like a punch to the chest, leaving Adora breathless. She wanted to tell Catra everything—about her parents, the relentless fights, the impossible decisions forced upon her. But how could she? How could she expect Catra to understand when she could barely make sense of it herself?

“Catra—” Adora began, her voice faltering.

“You don’t get to do that,” Catra interrupted, her voice low but trembling on the edges. “You don’t get to act like there wasn’t a choice made. Like you didn’t make it.”

Adora’s gaze dropped to the table, her focus locking onto a faint scratch in the surface. “I didn’t have a choice, Catra,” she said, her voice cracking under the weight of her frustration. “You weren’t in my head. I was drowning. And I couldn’t—” She paused, her breath hitching. “I wouldn’t bring you into that.”

For a long moment, the only sound was the soft clicking of a nearby keyboard. Adora almost thought Catra had left until her voice broke the silence.

“You could’ve given me a choice,” Catra said quietly. “You didn’t even give me the chance to decide.”

The words settled heavily between them. Adora’s stomach twisted. It was one thing to know she’d hurt someone; it was another to see the pain she’d caused etched so plainly in their eyes. She wanted to speak, to explain, to apologize in a way that would actually matter.

“I’m sorry,” Adora whispered. It was all she could manage.

Catra’s voice softened, though it still carried the weight of her hurt. “Yeah.” She let out a shaky breath. “But sorry doesn’t really fix it, does it?”

Adora looked up at her, offering a small, half-hearted smile. “No. But it’s all I’ve got.”

The silence between them was thick, unyielding. Adora searched for a way to bridge it, but every thought felt inadequate, every word hollow.

“So what?” Catra finally broke the tension, her voice laced with sarcasm. She leaned forward, gesturing to her notebook. “Are we

just supposed to dive back into this and pretend none of it happened?"

Adora chuckled softly, the sound almost surprising her. "Wouldn't be the worst idea I've ever had."

Catra snorted, a faint smile tugging at her lips. "That sounds like a terrible plan."

For a moment, Adora didn't know how to react. For the first time in five years, Catra smiled—really smiled—at her.

"Yeah," Adora agreed, her voice soft. "But maybe we could come up with a better one? Together?"

Catra didn't respond immediately, but she didn't leave either. Instead, she flipped her notebook open to a blank page and began tapping her pen on the table. "Fine," she said eventually. "But if you start acting all high and mighty, I'm out."

Adora's lips curved into a small smirk. "Deal."

For the first time, the tension between them eased. It wasn't much, but it was something. And for now, that was enough.

Adora leaned back in her chair, letting out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding. The silence between them was oddly comforting—not peace, exactly, but no longer outright war.

She watched as the sky outside shifted from blue to hues of orange and pink, streaked with purple. A strange sort of nostalgia tugged at her chest, an ache for something she knew she could never fully return to.

Catra was typing on her laptop now, her focus seemingly elsewhere. But for a brief moment, she glanced up. Their eyes met, and Adora felt memories rise unbidden—nights of uncontrollable laughter as they crept back to their dorm, hushed whispers in the dark, the warmth of Catra's hand brushing against hers.

“Adora?” Catra’s voice pulled her back to the present.

“What?” Adora blinked, realizing she’d been staring again.

“You good, or do you plan to slack off all night?”

Adora shook her head, turning back to her notebook. “Yeah, I’m good. Just... remembering something.”

Catra raised an eyebrow, but let it drop, returning to her work.

Adora tried to refocus on the project, but her thoughts kept slipping away to the past. It wasn’t just the here and now that they had to navigate—it was the weight of everything that had come before.

Swallowing hard, she forced herself to concentrate. The past wasn’t done with her yet.

Chapter End Notes

I am SO excited for the next chapter—woohoo!

See you soon!!

Chapter 5 (FLASHBACK)

Chapter Notes

> Oh my goodness, hello! I'm SO, SO sorry for the break between chapters. As I mentioned in the last update, I started back at school and work, and with the TikTok ban, I've been focusing on my YouTube and other platforms. BUT IT'S HERE!!!
>
> Just a quick heads-up: From now on, you can expect new chapters to be posted on Sunday nights! I'll do my absolute best to keep them on schedule unless something crazy comes up.
>
> Thank you so much for reading and for your patience!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 5 : Adora

Flashback

There's a certain stillness at night that makes it nearly impossible to escape your own mind. The quiet amplifies every thought, every memory, until they're practically screaming in front of you. You try your hardest not to let them in, to keep the past at bay, but it slips through the cracks—persistent, unrelenting, like whispers in the dark that refuse to leave.

Adora hated it. She hated the way her mind flitted between fragments of memories, replaying moments she thought she'd locked away. She tried to push them down, to drown them out with other thoughts, but they always clawed their way back in.

Tonight was no different.

She stared at the ceiling, the faint hum of cars passing by filtering through the cracked window. She regretted buying blackout

curtains; the darkness only seemed to make it easier for the memories to creep in. And a part of her—a part she despised—wanted to give in, wanted to remember. Guilt and discomfort twisted inside her, keeping her wide awake as she played a futile game of tug-of-war with her own mind.

But tonight, she wasn't winning.

Before she could stop it, she was dragged back into the past.

To UCLA.

Adora lay uncomfortably cramped on the twin-size mattress in their old dorm, her arm outstretched and pinned beneath a familiar weight. The tiny room was quiet, save for the occasional sound of doors shutting and footsteps overhead.

She had woken up to find Catra sprawled across her bed—again. One arm was draped over Adora's middle, the other clutching her arm as if the brunette were afraid Adora might slip away. Catra's head was tucked against Adora's shoulder, her curls tickling her neck. The half-open blinds let in just enough light to catch the suncatcher Catra had hung during their first week in the dorm, scattering faint rainbows across the far wall.

This wasn't unusual. Catra crashing in Adora's bed and leaving her perfectly fine bunk untouched had become a regular occurrence during their time at UCLA, especially during exam weeks. What had started as a one-time thing—an all-nighter that stretched too late—had turned into a comfortable habit neither of them questioned.

Adora didn't mind. Or at least, that's what she kept telling herself.

That morning, she lay perfectly still, her breath shallow as her eyes traced the faint patterns of light on the ceiling. Her heart thundered in her chest, loud enough to wake Catra—or so it felt. Why did she let this happen? Why did she invite this panic every time?

But somehow, the thought of not having this—these small, stolen moments—felt so much worse than a little anxiety.

Adora knew it was wrong—wasn't it? She knew it would never lead to anything. Right? And yet, she couldn't bring herself to pull away. She couldn't stop herself from wanting more.

Her eyes flickered to the suncatcher, its faint rainbows casting shifting patterns in the dim light, almost like a kaleidoscope. It was one of the many small touches Catra had insisted on adding to the room to make it feel "less like a jail cell." A tiny, colorful rebellion against the institutional beige walls.

Adora had teased the brunette for it at the time, but now, watching the soft colors turn, twist, and dance, she couldn't help but feel grateful. It made the room feel vibrant. The blonde couldn't help but smile at the metaphor—the way an object Catra had brought had made a dull, beige room feel full of life, much like another situation she was experiencing firsthand.

Even though she felt completely overwhelmed by the weight of everything she wished she could say but couldn't.

Adora sighed softly, careful not to wake the sleeping girl next to her. Catra always had a way of doing that—turning the dull and ordinary into something dazzling without even trying. She didn't just bring life to the dorm; she brought it to Adora, too.

And that was the problem, wasn't it?

Adora's gaze drifted back to the ceiling. Every time she thought she had a firm grip on her feelings, they came rushing back—stronger, messier, impossible to ignore. She could lie to herself all she wanted during the day. Say they were just friends, try not to ruin a good thing. Throw herself into basketball practice, study an absurd amount, or go out with their friends. But in quiet moments like this one, there was no denying the truth standing right in front of her.

She was in love with Catra.

The realization hit her like it always did: sharp, undeniable, and completely terrifying.

She swallowed hard, her throat tightening. It wasn't like she hadn't tried to move past it, to shove those feelings back into the dark corner of her mind where they came from. But they always fought their way back to the surface, leaving claw marks as they did.

Adora didn't know why it felt so wrong. She couldn't put a name to the ache in her chest, the tightness in her lungs whenever she thought about it too hard. All she knew was that wanting Catra—wanting her like that—wasn't something she was supposed to feel.

Good friends didn't think about each other this way. Good people didn't feel this way.

She had tried to tell herself it was just a phase, but Catra was the only person Adora had ever felt a romantic pull toward. She had hoped it would be fleeting confusion, something that would fade with time. She had told herself this didn't mean anything. It couldn't. But then Catra would...

Laugh, or touch her arm, or sleep in the same bed as her—and all those carefully constructed walls would crumble.

A part of her—a huge, gaping part—told her, screamed at her, that this wasn't wrong. That she didn't have to feel this way. That it was okay. Okay to be happy. But that screaming voice always grew raspy, eventually drowned out by her parents' faces, their voices, the shame, the guilt, the gnawing fear that if she ever spoke these feelings aloud, it would ruin everything.

Her family.

She physically shook. She couldn't think about her parents while sharing a bed with Catra. The guilt was too much.

Catra would never feel the same.

Adora stared at the ceiling, forcing herself to count the tiles. Again. She had counted them a hundred times before, but she started again anyway, desperate for anything to quiet her thoughts.

One, two, three…

By the time she reached twenty, she let out a soft sigh. Twenty tiles. Twenty reasons to pull myself together.

Like usual, that didn't work.

Her chest felt heavy, swirling with thoughts she didn't want to face. And it didn't help that the blame for her constant confusion was literally draped across her. The way she smelled—warm vanilla and coffee, that familiar, dizzying reminder of how close they were. Adora inhaled too deeply, and the scent engulfed her.

One, two, three…

Catra stirred, letting out a low groan as she turned her face into Adora's shoulder. "You're thinking too loud again," she mumbled, her voice muffled but teasing.

Adora froze, her pulse spiking. "I'm not," she said, too quickly, too defensively. For a moment, she panicked, wondering if she'd been counting out loud without realizing it.

Catra cracked an eye open, her eyebrows knitting together. "Liar," she muttered, rolling onto her back. Her arm slipped away from Adora, leaving a phantom weight in its place. "What time is it?"

Adora glanced at the alarm clock on the nightstand. "Six? Maybe a little after," she said, her tone pointed. "Not that I'd know—someone won't let me sit up."

Catra snorted softly, rubbing her eyes with the heel of her hand as she stretched. "Drama queen," she muttered, her voice thick with grogginess. A small smirk tugged at her lips, betraying her teasing tone. "If it's that big of a deal, why didn't you just shove me off?"

Adora tried to look annoyed, but her own smirk betrayed her. "Maybe because you'd whine about it until we're in a nursing home, Miss I-Hold-Grudges."

"You're not wrong." Catra let out a content sigh as she stretched again, her arm brushing lightly against Adora's. She blinked a few times before closing her eyes entirely, her voice dropping back to a mumble. "But you're still thinking too loud. What's eating at you now?"

Adora hesitated, a shiver running down her spine. What wasn't eating at her? She wanted to brush it off, say something vague, something casual. But Catra… even half-asleep, Catra made her falter.

"Just…" Adora's eyes drifted to the ceiling tiles.

One, two, three…

"Just stuff. Finals. Practice. Life."

Catra hummed, unconvinced but too tired to care. "Well, whatever it is, stop overthinking it. It's annoying."

Adora rolled her eyes, but the corner of her lip twitched up despite herself. "Thanks for the world-class advice. Really life-changing."

"I do what I can." Catra smirked as she yanked the blankets over her shoulder. "Now stop worrying. You'll be fine. You always are."

Adora wished she believed that. Catra seemed so content—why couldn't she feel the same? But Catra didn't carry the weight lodged in Adora's chest, the one that refused to be ignored. Of course Catra could drift back to sleep. She wasn't the one unraveling at every teasing glance, every casual touch that tied Adora in tighter knots.

As if on cue, Catra scooted closer, her warmth bleeding through Adora's T-shirt. "Go back to sleep, dumbass," she murmured,

already on the verge of drifting off again. “You’re gonna overthink yourself into the grave.”

Adora bit her lip, her throat dry, time dragging as she debated. She wanted to tell Catra—wanted to spill everything she’d been holding back for so long. But saying it felt impossible, like stepping into the unknown with no way back. Not saying it, though, was suffocating her.

The words, as always, stayed buried, tangled in fear and uncertainty. Instead, she let herself sink back against the mattress, her body trying—and failing—to relax.

“Yeah,” Adora muttered at last. “Maybe.”

The gym was silent. Adora was left alone in the locker room. Most of her teammates had left an hour or so ago, leaving her to her thoughts. The blonde lazily gathered her things into her backpack, stuffed her keys and phone into her pocket, and made her way to the parking lot. One of the perks of being an athlete at UCLA was getting close parking around back, so instead of exiting through the main entrance, she went out one of the back doors. She brushed a few strands of blonde hair from her face as she stepped into the crisp evening air. The sun had hit that perfect spot in the sky, casting a golden-orange hue across what was left of the day. The day had been long—classes, quick study sessions, and practice had left her muscles aching with exhaustion. But there was something comforting about this familiar end-of-day routine.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket, interrupting her thoughts.

Catra: You should come to the gig tonight.

Adora stared at the text until her screen went black. She felt her stomach knot. Her goal today had been not to think about Catra. Wasn’t much she could do when the girl had literally texted her. The message was short and direct—classic Catra. She realized she had been standing in the middle of the parking lot, staring at who

knows what, for the past five minutes. She forced her legs to walk her to her car.

The blonde threw her bag into the passenger seat and climbed into the sedan. Taking a breath, she opened her phone.

Adora: I don’t know, I’m wiped.

The reply came fast, almost immediately.

Catra: Come on, Perfect. Thought we got rid of the “I can't, I’m better than you” act.

Adora rolled her eyes, her thumb hovering over the keyboard. She knew she should say no—she usually did. Something always came up, and every time, she couldn’t tell if she was grateful or disappointed.

Adora let out a sigh, tossing her phone onto the dashboard. She leaned back in her seat, her head resting against the headrest as she watched the colors leave the sky. It shouldn’t be this hard, yes or no, right?

Her phone buzzed again.

Catra: I mean, I guess I should have known that Adora Gray was and always will be afraid of some fun. Can’t mess up that ponytail now, can we?

Adora scoffed, an involuntary smirk finding its way to her lips. That was a low blow, and Catra knew it. She typed up an excuse, but it didn’t feel right. Then another, then another. None of them felt convincing—not even to herself.

Adora: You must've texted the wrong person. I’m not afraid of anything.

Catra: Prove it. Be at Louis’s by 9.

Adora stared at the screen, feeling the knots in her stomach tighten with each passing second. She knew this was a bad idea. Every rational part of her screamed to stay home, to avoid the chaos and confusion that always seemed to follow the brunette.

But the other part of her—the part she'd been trying to ignore for years—was curious, maybe even excited.

Adora: Fine, but if it's terrible, I'm walking.

Catra: Don't worry, I'm far from it. See you tonight, Perfect.

Adora groaned as she tossed her phone into the passenger seat and started her car. What was she doing? She didn't even like bars. The loud music, the crowded spaces—it wasn't her thing.

But it was Catra's thing.

Adora adjusted her jacket as she approached the entrance of Louis's. Low conversation and laughter spilled out from inside, mixed with music. Louis's was one of those college bars everyone went to. It was in the busier part of town, on a strip surrounded by smaller stores and restaurants. The blonde hesitated, her finger gripping the door handle.

You don't have to do this, she told herself.

But as if the universe had other plans, the door swung open—almost knocking her out. A group of young adults swarmed out, a few mumbling apologies. Adora recognized a few from school; the others seemed like complete strangers.

She smiled awkwardly as she held the door open for the rest of the group, then paused for a second to catch her breath before stepping inside.

The warmth hit her first. It wasn't terribly cold outside, but enough to make her glad she'd thrown on a jacket. Adora had spent thirty minutes in the shower, staring at the wall, contemplating whether she should even go. At one point, she

seriously considered "falling" in the shower, but that would've meant missing practice—and that was a non-starter. So, reluctantly, she forced herself to find an outfit. Sounds simple, right? No. The blonde had practically had a panic attack. After twenty minutes, she'd finally decided on a pair of blue jeans, a plain white tee, and a black jacket.

Now, standing among the crowd of college students, she felt out of place—not because of her outfit, but because she didn't know any of these people. Adora Gray didn't go out, and if she did, it was a planned event hosted by the team or her parents.

She watched as groups talked and laughed, drinks in hand, completely immersed in their own worlds. Adora tugged at her jacket sleeve nervously, scanning the crowd for a familiar face.

Her eyes finally landed on Catra, leaning casually against the bar with a drink in hand and a smirk on her face as she chatted with the bartender. Adora swallowed hard. Of course, Catra looked effortlessly cool. Her cropped leather jacket draped over her shoulders, and her hair framed her face in a way that seemed entirely effortless.

"Perfect!" Catra's voice cut through the low hum of the bar as she spotted Adora. She raised a hand in a half-wave, her expression somewhere between amused and smug.

Adora took a deep breath and pushed through the crowd, weaving between groups of students until she reached the bar.

"You actually showed up," Catra said as Adora approached, her tone teasing but her eyes softer than usual. "Didn't think you had it in you."

"Yeah, well," Adora shrugged, trying to ignore the heat creeping up her neck, "I guess I'm full of surprises."

Catra grinned, her fangs just barely peeking out. "I'll drink to that." She tapped the bar. "What'll it be, Gray? Don't tell me you're a soda-and-lime kind of girl."

Adora raised an eyebrow. “And if I am?”

“Then I’m buying it. Call it a charity effort.”

Adora rolled her eyes but couldn’t fight the small smile tugging at her lips. “Just a beer,” she said, leaning on the bar beside Catra.

A moment later, two drinks slid their way, and Catra led the way toward the back of the bar, where a small stage sat empty. She hopped up onto the edge of it with effortless grace, her legs swinging idly as she took a sip of her drink. Adora stood close by, leaning against one of the stage’s support beams.

Adora adjusted her drink, watching as Catra swung her legs over the edge of the stage. The brunette had an effortless way of making herself at home anywhere, her confidence radiating like a low hum in the room.

“So, what’s the verdict?” Catra asked, raising an eyebrow. “Louis’s as bad as you imagined?”

Adora took a sip of her beer, the cool liquid calming the nerves still buzzing in her chest. “It’s… not terrible,” she admitted. “A little loud, but not bad.”

Catra smirked. “High praise coming from you.”

Adora chuckled softly, setting her drink down beside Catra on the stage. She leaned against the support beam again, her eyes flickering around the bar before landing back on Catra.

“You always seem so comfortable in places like this,” Adora said, her tone softening. “I don’t know how you do it.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “What’s there to be uncomfortable about? It’s just people, music, drinks. Not exactly life or death.”

“Yeah, well,” Adora muttered with a faint smile, “I’m better at life or death.”

Catra laughed, the sound warm and unguarded. “Fair point. But you’ve gotta loosen up. Half the people here are too drunk to notice anyone else, and the other half are too busy trying to look cool.”

Adora shook her head, a small smile tugging at her lips. “It’s not that simple.”

“Sure it is,” Catra said, leaning back on her hands. Her gaze softened as she looked at Adora. “You just have to stop overthinking everything.”

Adora smiled despite herself, shaking her head. “You make it sound so easy.”

“That’s because it is,” Catra said simply, her gaze locking onto Adora’s. There was something unspoken in her eyes, something that made Adora’s breath hitch. “You just have to stop thinking so much.”

“Easier said than done,” Adora murmured.

“Then maybe you need a distraction.”

Catra leaned back on her hands, her smirk softening into something more genuine. The air between them felt charged, and Adora couldn’t tell if it was the beer or the way Catra was looking at her that made her heart race.

Adora glanced away, suddenly aware of how close they were standing. “You always make it sound so simple.”

“Maybe it is,” Catra replied, her voice quieter now.

Adora hesitated, her fingers brushing the edge of the stage as she reached behind Catra to steady herself. The movement brought her closer, close enough to catch the faint scent of Catra’s perfume mixed with the leather of her jacket.

“You know,” Catra said, her voice barely above a whisper, “you don’t have to overthink everything. Sometimes… you just go with it.”

Adora’s gaze flickered to Catra’s lips, then back to her eyes. “Go with it?” she echoed, her voice unsteady.

Catra nodded, her smirk returning but softer this time, almost teasing. “Yeah. Like this.”

She leaned in slightly, her movements unhurried, giving Adora all the time in the world to back away. But Adora didn’t move. Her breath caught as Catra’s face drew closer.

When their lips finally met, it was tentative, like the first note of a song. Adora’s eyes fluttered shut, her nerves giving way to something warmer, something undeniable. Catra’s lips were soft against hers, her hand moving to rest lightly on Adora’s forearm, grounding her.

The kiss deepened slowly, neither of them rushing, as if they were testing the waters of something they both knew had been building for longer than either would admit. Adora felt her heart pound in her chest, but it wasn’t fear—it was exhilaration, like standing on the edge of a cliff and finally taking the leap.

Catra pulled back just enough to catch her breath, her forehead resting lightly against Adora’s. “See?” she murmured, her voice teasing but laced with something softer. “Not so scary, is it?”

Adora laughed softly, her cheeks flushed, her hands still gripping the stage for balance. “You’re impossible.”

Catra grinned, her thumb brushing gently against Adora’s arm. “And you’re predictable.”

Adora raised an eyebrow, her confidence returning in a small wave. “Oh, yeah?”

“Yeah,” Catra said, leaning in close again, her voice a low murmur against Adora’s ear. “But I like that about you.”

Adora felt her breath catch again, but this time, she didn’t hesitate. She closed the distance between them, her lips meeting Catra’s in a kiss that was bolder, more certain. Catra responded instantly, her hands sliding to Adora’s waist, pulling her closer as their connection deepened.

The sounds of the bar faded away entirely, leaving only the warmth of the moment between them. For once, Adora wasn’t overthinking, wasn’t second-guessing. She was just there, with Catra, and it felt like exactly where she was meant to be.

Chapter End Notes

RAHHHHH! How are we feeling? CATRADORA FLASHBACK, HEHEHE! I love them so much, and I can’t wait for the next chapters! Also, y’all already know the drill—I was HEAVY into "Kaleidoscope" by Chappell Roan and "Into It" by Chase Atlantic while writing this.

HEHE, anywho, BYYYY for now :)

End Notes

HELLO!! OMG, first chapter! Personally, I love this idea. I'm writing this in third person due to the multiple POVs.
Little fun note: I imagine Fading Lines' first song to be Midnight Love by Girl in Red. :)
Anywho, bye for now!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!